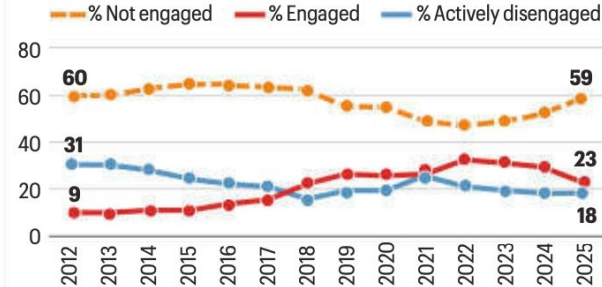


DECODED EXPLAINED

24th August, 2026

'Quiet Quitting' Rising Among Indian Workers

● 'Quiet quitting' rising among Indian workers



● The phrase 'quiet quitting' went viral in 2022. And new research by analytics and advisory company Gallup shows the share of Indian workers who are not engaged — sometimes described as 'quiet quitting' as they only meet the basic requirements and invest little discretionary effort — rose to **59%** in 2025 from **46%** in 2022.

● According to Gallup, India's current level of disengagement costs **\$351 billion** in lost workplace productivity each year. This is equivalent to about **9%** of GDP. "This figure should sound an alarm and make the country's declining engagement a national economic crisis," a Gallup report, released Saturday, said.

18% The percentage of employees who are actively disengaged has flatlined.

23% The share of engaged staff has declined.

SOURCE: GALLUP-INSTITUTE OF DIRECTORS REPORT

'Quiet Quitting' Rising Among Indian Workers

- **The Trend**

The phrase 'quiet quitting' went viral in 2022; new Gallup research shows the share of Indian workers who are 'not engaged' meeting only basic requirements rose to 59% in 2025 from 46% in 2022.

- **The Economic Cost**

Gallup estimates India's current level of disengagement costs \$351 billion in lost workplace productivity each year : about 9% of GDP.

- **Reasons for Quiet Quitting**

- Thinking away from Hustle Culture
- Health
- Corporate Earning is less
- More awareness about work life balance
- Lack of career growth

Importance of Elephant Corridors in Reducing Conflict

Importance of elephant corridors in reducing conflict

Nikhil Ghoshkar
New Delhi, August 23

A 10-member court bench led by Chief Justice of India D.Y. Chandrachud last week directed the Centre to conduct a fresh survey of elephant corridors. It said these corridors cannot be blocked fearing crop damage as elephant needs, by nature, travel long distances.

The bench was hearing a writ petition on managing human-elephant conflict. The petition, in the past, had sought to prevent the use of fireballs, snakes and other such materials to drive away elephants. In its order, the Bench asked the Centre to indicate steps taken to prohibit the use of such methods or any other "coercive measures" to divert the natural movement of elephants.

Moving long distances

Asian elephants are highly mobile and social mammals. A male elephant's average home range — the area it typically uses for food, water and shelter — extends between 50 and 200 sq km. Elephants can move through their range in herds or individually. These home ranges can also extend depending on habitat type, food availability, water sources, population density and human disturbances.

Elephant corridors, or movement pathways connecting two natural habitats, are crucial to facilitating elephant movement. Disrupting them can not only spark human-elephant conflict but pose a threat to the animals.

Elephant movements are strongly influenced by seasonal and spatial distribution of food, water and habitat, according to studies. For instance, seasonal migrations into Kerala are common during the dry months as elephants seek water and food in the relatively moist forests of the Western Ghats, said a recent Environment Ministry report. Historically, climate change and drought, too, have played a role in forcing migrations.

150 IN 15 STATES

- Elephant corridors are movement pathways connecting two natural habitats.
- The government's last major mapping exercise in 2023 documented 150 elephant corridors across 15 states.

Fragmented corridors

The directions given by the court pertained to blocking or obstruction of elephant corridors passing through different states, and the related issues of human-elephant conflict it creates.

The major issues in recent disruptions of corridors are infrastructure construction, and industrial and mining activity. Highways, existing and new railway lines, canals and power lines can push elephants towards farmlands and human settlements, triggering conflict.

India has four principal elephant populations: the Western Ghats, North-Eastern Hills and Brahmaputra floodplains, Shivalik Hills and Gangetic plains, and Central India and Eastern Ghats.

The habitat of the Western Ghats population is rapidly getting fragmented owing to changing land use, mining, dams and farmland fencing. This was noted in the last all-India elephant population estimation report released last year. Similar disruptions were recorded in the Shivalik and Brahmaputra plains.

The biggest challenge, however, lies in Central India and Eastern Ghats. Chhattisgarh has seen elephants arriving from Jharkhand and Odisha over two decades owing to habitat loss and mining pressures. Elephants have also expanded their range into parts of Madhya Pradesh and Maharashtra.

Corridor mapping

Corridors allow elephants genetic exchange or dispersal, which helps in maintaining diversity in their populations pool. Well-conserved corridors also provide them access to food and water in natural habitats during seasonal changes, preventing them from resorting to crop raiding.



Sign for elephant crossing in Velpura, Tamil Nadu.
ANIL KUMAR

Importance of Elephant Corridors in Reducing Conflict

- **The Court's Directive**

- A Supreme Court Bench led by CJI Surya Kant directed the Centre to conduct a fresh survey of elephant corridors, holding they cannot be blocked for fear of crop damage since elephant herds, by nature, travel long distances.
- The Bench asked the Centre to indicate steps taken to prohibit fireballs, spikes, and other coercive methods used to divert elephants' natural movement.

- **Why Elephants Need Long-Distance Corridors**

- A male elephant's average home range extends 50-300 sq km, varying by habitat type, food availability, water sources, population density, and human disturbance.
- Elephant corridors connecting two natural habitats are crucial for this movement; disrupting them sparks human-elephant conflict and threatens the animals climate change and drought further force migration.

- **The Scale and Fragmentation of the Problem**

- The government's last major mapping exercise (2023) documented 150 elephant corridors across 15 States; infrastructure, industrial activity, and mining push elephants towards farmlands, triggering conflict.
- India has four elephant landscapes: Western Ghats; North-Eastern Hills and Brahmaputra floodplains; Shivalik Hills and Gangetic plains; and Central India and Eastern Ghats, the latter facing the biggest challenge from habitat loss and mining.

- **Why Corridor Mapping Matters**

- Corridors allow elephants genetic exchange and dispersal, maintaining diversity in their population pool.
- Well-conserved corridors provide access to food and water during seasonal changes, preventing elephants from entering crop lands in the first place.

Chipflation: Electronics See Years of Price Hikes in 6 Months

Chipflation: Electronics see years of price hikes replicated in 6 mths

Consumers are increasingly looking out for promotional offers because of rising electronics prices, say analysts

Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, August 23

THE GLOBAL artificial intelligence (AI) investment boom has created an acute shortage of the memory chips used in the manufacture of everyday consumer electronics.

This has led to manufacturers raising rates they charge to such an extent that years of price hikes that occurred in the past for products such as smartphones and TVs have taken place in just six months in 2026.

According to Consumer Price Index (CPI) data from the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI), prices of a variety of consumer electronics goods in July were up 3-5% compared to January.

The price movements were far more sedate in 2025.

Take mobile handsets. Compared to a 4% rise from January 2026 to July 2026, the same period in 2025 had seen its CPI price index decline by 0.7%. Or take air conditioners. While they normally do see higher prices in the summer, the extent of the increase this year has been 4.8% compared to 1.1% between January-July 2025. Go back further and 2026's price hikes become even

more striking. Since January 2026, the CPI index of TVs is up 3.5%. If one counts back from December 2025, matching this magnitude of increase took 54 months, or four-and-a-half years. The numbers are similarly large for other consumer electronics: 46 for ACs, 45 for fridges, 41 for mobile phones, 32 for washing machines, and 31 for computers and laptops.

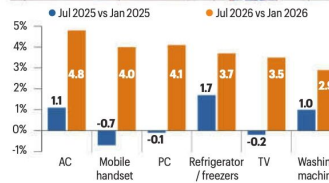
The increase in price indices over 2026 of the aforementioned six consumer electronics is calculated as per the new CPI series which has 2024 as the base year. For the period prior to 2026, price index changes are computed using the old CPI series which had 2012 as the base year. Only consumer electronics items present in both the old and new CPI baskets have been compared.

'Chipflation'

Back in June, analysts at American investment bank Morgan Stanley had coined the term 'chipflation' to describe how "AI's appetite for memory chips is boosting the cost of everything from data centers to smartphones, with consequences that may reach far beyond the tech industry."

The global AI boom has led to key chipmakers such as

•CHIPFLATION PUSHING UP PRICES OF CONSUMER ELECTRONICS



NOTE: FIGURES ARE CHANGE IN EACH ITEM'S PRICE INDEX AS PER NEW CPI SERIES. SOURCE: MOSPI

TSMC, Samsung, and SK Hynix making the more in-demand and advanced chips used in data centres sprouting up all over the world.

What is being sacrificed are DRAM (Dynamic Random Access Memory) and other chips used in everyday electronics goods such as refrigerators, washing machines, ACs, smart-

phones, laptops, TVs, and earphones. The result of the supply shortage of the chips essential to consumer electronics is a massive rise in their prices, with JPMorgan Global Research estimating DRAM prices will have risen more than 400% from the start of 2024 to the end of 2026. This is in stark contrast to Moore's Law driven cost reduc-

tion seen over the second half of the 20th century and the first 20 or so years of the 21st century: DRAM prices fell 90% every five years over this period. "New memory capacity takes years to build, qualify and ramp up. Supply relief is a process, not a switch. And that creates a two-tier market. Large AI and cloud buyers can sign long-term agreements, prepay and secure priority access. Traditional buyers, including PC makers, smartphone makers and industrial hardware companies, must compete for what remains," Shawn Kim, Head of Morgan Stanley's Europe and Asia Technology Team, said in a podcast in June.

Eyes on promotions

According to Kim, the shortfall in memory chips in 2027 is equivalent to what is needed to make 134 million phones. Already, in the April-June quarter, global smartphone exports were down 18% - their second-lowest level since 2013 - as per Counterpoint Research.

In India, smartphone sales fell for three weeks in a row after online promotional events in July. "...rising device prices are making consumers increasingly value-conscious and more dependent on promotional offers," said Prachir Singh, Senior Analyst at Counterpoint Research, who added that this trend has become more visible over the past few months.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Chipflation: Electronics See Years of Price Hikes in 6 Months

- **'Chipflation'**
 - A term coined by Morgan Stanley describing how AI's demand for memory chips is driving up consumer electronics prices amid a chip supply shortage.
- **Moore's Law**
 - The historical trend of computing power/cost efficiency roughly doubling every couple of years, leading to falling chip prices temporarily reversed for certain memory chips by chipflation.

Barren-Land Fallacy

Barren-land fallacy

Vasudevan Mukunth

Trees provide many benefits, including helping cool the neighbourhood, keeping soil from getting eroded, drawing carbon from the environment and storing it, and supporting many birds, small animals, and insects. However, these effects are beneficial only when trees are in the right ecosystem; otherwise, they can be harmful.

The barren-land fallacy is the idea that land that does not have tree cover is barren land, thus ecologically deficient, and that it will 'evolve' or should be helped to 'evolve' into a forest. The tree-planting drives that happen in India often perpetuate this fallacy by planting trees in the wrong ecosystems. They often also plant trees that are unsuitable for the local conditions, e.g. eucalyptus trees — which draw a lot of water — in a water-stressed area.

Forests are only one kind of ecosystem. Others include grasslands, savannah, scrubland, wetlands, and deserts, plus many naturally open ecosystems. As University of California professor of history and geography Diana Davis has written, "The assumption that the world's drylands are worthless, deforested, and overgrazed landscapes has led ... to programs and policies that have often systematically damaged dryland environments".

To ecologically restore a place does not always mean planting more trees.



The Sahel region in Mali is a semi-desert landscape. TIMM GUENTHER (CC BY-SA)

Instead, it is to do whatever will protect or restore the ecosystem that would naturally occur there. In the same vein, planting trees or regenerating forests is only valuable where forests have been degraded or cleared and where a forest is the native ecosystem.

For feedback and suggestions

for 'Science', please write to science@thehindu.co.in with the subject 'Daily page'

Barren-Land Fallacy

- **The Core Idea**

- Trees provide many benefits cooling, preventing soil erosion, storing carbon, supporting biodiversity but these effects are beneficial only when trees are in the right ecosystem; otherwise, they can be harmful.
- The 'barren-land fallacy' is the idea that land without tree cover is inherently deficient and should 'evolve' into forest; Indian tree-planting drives often perpetuate this, planting unsuitable species like eucalyptus in water-stressed areas.

- **Forests Are Just One Kind of Ecosystem**

- Other ecosystems include grasslands, savannah, scrubland, wetlands, and deserts; as geographer Diana Davis notes, assuming the world's drylands are 'worthless' has led to policies that have systematically damaged dryland environments.
- Ecological restoration does not always mean planting more trees it means protecting or restoring whatever ecosystem would naturally occur in a given place.

- **Applying the Principle Correctly**

- Planting trees or regenerating forests is only genuinely valuable where forests have been degraded or cleared and forest is the native ecosystem applying this logic to a natural grassland or scrubland can disrupt rather than improve it.